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8.1 INTRODUCTION

8.1.1 This chapter assesses the landscape and visual effects of the Proposed Development and forms a Landscape and Visual Impact Assessment (LVIA).

8.1.2 The chapter should be read in conjunction with **Appendix 8** (Volume 2 of the ES), which includes plans, figures and accompanying documents.

8.1.3 The chapter has been prepared by FPCR Environment & Design Ltd.

8.2 ASSESSMENT METHODOLOGY

Scope

8.2.1 The study area for the LVIA has been defined by the field work undertaken as part of the baseline landscape and visual stage of the LVIA. The study area includes the site and the surrounding local landscape, together with the wider landscape where there maybe potential landscape and visual effects as a result of the Proposed Development. The study area is effectively shown by Figure 8.1 (**appendix 8.1**)

Data Sources

8.2.2 This Landscape and Visual Impact Assessment has been prepared based upon the Guidelines for Landscape and Visual Impact Assessment, Third Edition (GLVIA3), published by the Landscape Institute and the Institute of Environmental Management and Assessment in April 2013.

8.2.3 In summary, the GVLIA3 states:

> "Landscape and Visual Impact Assessment (LVIA) is a tool used to identify and assess the significance of, and the effects of, change resulting from development on both landscape as an environmental resource in its own right and on people's views and visual amenity."

8.2.4 There are two components of LVIA:

- Assessment of landscape effects - assessing effects on the landscape as a resource in its own right; and
- Assessment of visual effects - assessing effects on specific views and on the general visual amenity experienced by people.

8.2.5 These two elements are described separately within this chapter.

8.2.6 The GLVIA3 recognises that professional judgement is a very important part of LVIA, and states that whilst there is some scope for quantitative measurements of some relatively objective matters, much of the assessment must rely on qualitative judgements (para. 2.23). It also states that in identifying significant effects:

"the need for an approach that is in proportion to the scale of the project that is being assessed and the nature of the likely effects, judgement needs to be exercised at all stages in terms of the scale of the investigation that is appropriate and proportional" (para. 1.17).

Assessment Approach

8.2.7 The components of the LVIA include: a project description; baseline studies; identification and description of potential effects; assessment of the significance of those effects; and consideration of their mitigation. This report outlines these components.

8.2.8 In terms of baseline studies, the assessment provides an understanding of the landscape in the area to be affected, its constituent elements, character, condition and value. For the visual baseline, this includes an understanding of the area in which the Proposed Development may be visible, the people who may experience views and the nature of views.

8.2.9 The overall significance of effects is determined by making a judgement about two components:

- The nature of the receptor likely to be affected (known by the shorthand 'sensitivity') and;
- The nature of the effect likely to occur (known by the shorthand 'magnitude').

8.2.10 Judgements on sensitivity are made by considering:

- The susceptibility of the receptor to the type of change arising from the specific proposal; and
- The value attached to the receptor.

8.2.11 Judgements on magnitude are made by considering:

- The size and scale of the effect, for example whether there is a complete loss of a particular element of the landscape or a minor change;
- The geographical extent of the area that will be affected; and
- The duration of the effect and its reversibility.

8.2.12 Consideration of all of the above criteria feeds into a comprehensive assessment of significance.

8.2.13 Mitigation includes measures proposed to prevent, reduce and, where possible, offset any significant adverse effects. Mitigation provided as part of the Proposed Development is included within the overall assessment of effects.

Assessment of Landscape Effects

8.2.14 GLVIA3 states that:

"An assessment of landscape effects deals with the effects of change and development on landscape as a resource".

8.2.15 The baseline landscape is described by reference to existing landscape character assessments and by a description of the Site and its immediate context.

8.2.16 A range of landscape effects can arise through development. These can include:-

- Change or loss of elements, features, aesthetic or perceptual aspects that contribute to the character and distinctiveness of the landscape;
- Addition of new elements that influence character and distinctiveness of the landscape; and
- Combined effects of these changes.

8.2.17 These are discussed within the assessment.

Susceptibility to Change and Value of the Landscape Receptor

8.2.18 The characteristics of the existing landscape resource are considered in respect of the susceptibility of the landscape resource to the change arising from the development.

8.2.19 The value of the existing landscape is also considered. The GLVIA3 indicates information that contributes to understanding landscape value. This information is set out in paragraph 5.20 of the GLVIA3 and includes:

- Information about areas recognised by statute such as National Parks and Areas of Outstanding Natural Beauty;

- Information about Heritage Coasts, where relevant;
- Local planning documents, for local landscape designations;
- Information on individual or groups of features such as conservation areas, listed buildings, special historic or cultural sites;
- Art and literature, identifying value attached to particular areas or views; and
- Material on landscape of local or community interest.

8.2.20 Where there is no clear existing evidence on landscape value, an assessment is made based on the following factors, as outlined within the GLVIA3:

- Landscape quality (condition);
- Scenic quality;
- Rarity;
- Representativeness;
- Conservation interest;
- Recreation value;
- Perceptual aspects; and
- Associations.

Magnitude of Landscape Effects

8.2.21 Each effect on landscape receptors is assessed in terms of size or scale, geographical extent of the area influenced and its duration and reversibility.

8.2.22 In terms of size or scale the judgement takes account of the extent of the existing landscape elements that will be lost or changed, and the degree to which the aesthetic or perceptual aspects or key characteristics of the landscape will be altered by removal or addition of new elements. This assessment describes scale and size by reference to the terms 'High',' Medium' and 'Low'.

8.2.23 The geographical extent of the effect is described by reference to the site, its immediate context and wider landscape character areas. The duration and reversibility of effects are also described.

Overall Significance of Landscape Effects

8.2.24 The overall significance of landscape effects is determined by considering the sensitivity of the landscape receptors and the magnitude of effect on the landscape.

8.2.25 The landscape sensitivity is determined by considering the susceptibility to change and the value of the landscape receptor. Judgements about the susceptibility to change are recorded on a scale of 'High', 'Medium' and 'Low'. The value of the landscape is recorded on a scale of 'National', 'Regional' or 'Local'. The magnitude of landscape change is defined in terms of 'High', 'Medium', 'Low' or 'Negligible' effects, see **Appendix 8.3.**

8.2.26 The GLVIA3 notes, at paragraph 5.46, that there can be complex relationships between the value attached to landscape receptors, and their susceptibility to change. As an example, a nationally valued landscape does not automatically have a high susceptibility to all types of change.

8.2.27 Final conclusions regarding the overall significance of landscape effects are drawn from the assessment components described. The GLVIA3 notes, at paragraph 5.56, that there are no “hard and fast rules” about what makes a significant effect. However it is reasonable to state that:

- Major loss or irreversible negative effects, over an extensive area, on elements and/or aesthetic and perceptual aspects that are key to the character of nationally valued landscapes are likely to be of the greatest significance;
- Reversible negative effects of short duration, over a restricted area, on elements and/or aesthetic and perceptual aspects that contribute to but are not key characteristics of the character of landscapes of community value are likely to be of least significance and may, depending on the circumstances, be judged as not significant; and
- Where assessments of significance place landscape effects between these extremes, judgements must be made about whether or not they are significant, with full explanations of why these conclusions have been reached.

8.2.28 This assessment includes conclusions on the significance of the landscape effects.

Assessment of Visual Effects

8.2.29 An assessment of visual effects deals with the effects of change and development on the views available to people and their visual amenity.

8.2.30 Field evaluation has been used to establish a series of viewpoints. These have been used to represent a range of potential viewpoints.

8.2.31 The viewpoints include:

- Views to aid description of the Site itself (where considered appropriate);
- Public viewpoints, including rights of way and open access land;
- Public locations representing residential areas;
- Transport routes; and
- Places where people work.

8.2.32 The views also represent what can be seen from a variety of distances towards the Proposed Development, and thus provide different viewing experiences.

Sensitivity of Visual Receptors

8.2.33 For each affected viewpoint the assessment considers both susceptibility to change in views and the value attached to views.

8.2.34 The visual receptors most susceptible to change are generally likely to include:

- Residents at home;
- People engaged in outdoor recreation, including users of public rights of way, whose attention or interest is likely to be focused on the landscape or particular views;
- Visitors to heritage assets or other attractions, where views of surroundings are an important contributor to the experience; and
- Communities where views contribute to the landscape setting enjoyed by residents within the area.
- Travellers on road, rail or other transport routes tend to fall into an intermediate category of susceptibility to change. Where travel involves recognised scenic routes, awareness of views is likely to be particularly high.

8.2.35 Visual receptors less likely to be sensitive to change include:

- People engaged in outdoor sport or recreation which does not involve or depend upon appreciation of views of the landscape; and
- People at their place of work whose attention may be focused on their work or activity, not on their surroundings.

8.2.36 Judgements about susceptibility to change are recorded in this assessment on a scale of 'High', 'Medium' and 'Low'.

8.2.37 Judgements on the value attached to views experienced takes account of:-

- Recognition of the value attached to particular views, for example in relation to heritage assets or through planning designations; and
- Indicators of the value attached to views by visitors, for example through appearances in guidebooks or visitor maps.
- Judgements on visual value within this assessment are assessed as 'High', 'Medium' and 'Low'.

Magnitude of the Visual Effects

8.2.38 Each of the visual effects is evaluated in terms of its size or scale, the geographical extent of the area influenced and its duration or reversibility.

8.2.39 In terms of size or scale, the magnitude of visual effects takes account of:

- The scale of the change in the view with respect to the loss or addition of features in the view and changes in its composition, including the proportion of the view occupied by the Proposed Development;
- The degree of contrast or integration of any new features or changes in the landscape with the existing or remaining landscape elements and characteristics; and
- The nature of the view of the Proposed Development, in terms of the relative amount of time over which it will be experienced and whether views will be full, partial or glimpses.

8.2.40 The geographical extent of the visual effect in each viewpoint is likely to reflect:

- The angle of view in relation to the main activity of the receptor;
- The distance of the viewpoint from the Proposed Development; and

- The extent of the area over which the changes will be visible.
- As with landscape effects the duration of the effect could be short to long term or permanent and the same definitions apply.

Overall Significance of Landscape and Visual Effects

8.2.41 The final conclusions on significance are drawn from the separate judgements on the sensitivity of the receptors and the magnitude of the effects, see **Appendix 8.4**

8.2.42 For this assessment, the following description thresholds have been used

- Major: an effect considered very important in the decision process;
- Major/Moderate: an effect that is considered material in the decision process;
- Moderate: an effect that is notable, but not material in the decision process;
- Minor: an effect that will be noticed, but is not relevant to the decision process;
- Negligible: an effect that will be discernible but of very limited consequences that is it not relevant to the decision process.

8.3 RELEVANT POLICY

National Planning Policy Framework (March 2012)

8.3.1 The NPPF seeks to conserve and enhance the natural environment, protecting and enhancing valued landscapes:

"The planning system should contribute to and enhance the natural and local environment by: Protecting and enhancing valued landscapes..." (para. 109)
"Local planning authorities should set criteria based policies against which proposals for a development on or affecting protected wildlife or geodiversity sites or landscape areas will be judged." (para. 113)

8.3.2 The NPPF also states that local planning authorities should:

"Set out a strategic approach in their Local Plans, planning positively for the creation, protection, enhancement and management of networks of biodiversity and green infrastructure" (para. 114)

Swindon Borough Local Plan (2011 (2006))

8.3.3 Policy DS6 includes the following elements:

"Development proposals shall
e) respect and accommodate any existing features of acknowledged importance including trees and hedgerows on, or in the vicinity of, the site; and
g) incorporate suitable landscaping, including where necessary landscaping
to mitigate the impact of the development and any necessary associated activities (for example parking, external storage)"

8.3.4 Policy ENV10 deals with landscape character:
"Within the countryside the Local Planning Authority shall seek to protect and enhance the character and quality of the environment. Development shall only be permitted where it takes account of its natural surroundings and their landscape character."

8.3.5 Policy ENV13 is concerned with rural buffers:

"Development within rural buffers, as defined on the Proposals Map, shall only be permitted where it retains or enhances the existing character of the countryside and:

a) involves the reuse, conversion or extension of existing buildings at a scale appropriate to their location, in accordance with the criteria specified in Policy DS7; or

b) is an essential requirement directly related to the economic or social needs of the rural community; or

c) comprises an individual element of a Borough wide park and ride strategy; or

d) is for the on-site expansion of existing educational establishments.

8.3.6 All of Swindon Borough, in addition to adjoining areas of adjacent local authorities, lies within the Great Western Community Forest. Policy ENV19 states:

"Development shall only be permitted where it does not prejudice the implementation of the Great Western Community Forest."

Draft Swindon Borough Local Plan 2026

8.3.7 The *Swindon Borough Local Plan 2026: Submission Document (2013)* is the emerging main planning policy document for the Borough and sets out the level and location of growth up to 2026.

New Eastern Villages

8.3.8 Policy NC3 allocates an extensive area of land for new mixed-use development to the east of Swindon. This includes around 6,000 dwellings at the New Eastern Villages (south of the A420), around 1,500 dwellings at Rowborough (north of the A420) and 500 dwellings at South Marston.

8.3.9 Policy NC3 is not repeated in full, but the following specific landscape issues are set out below:

"b. The development shall provide:

- An extensive green infrastructure network that maximises opportunities for habitat connectivity and enhanced biodiversity including extending the River Cole green infrastructure corridor and connecting with Nightingale Wood;
- Sports and leisure facilities.

c. The development will ensure:

- The landscape context and views to and from the North Wessex Downs AONB are respected, including potential off-site mitigation;
- Biodiversity including the River Cole corridor and River Cole Meadow County Wildlife Sites is protected, integrated and enhanced; and
- The historic environment, including the Scheduled Monument, Earlscourt Manor, Great Moorleaze Farm and other Listed Buildings are protected, acknowledged and enhanced.

The character and identity of South Marston will be protected as set out in Policy RA3."

8.3.10 Design and Green infrastructures principles are outlined in paragraphs 5.56 and 5.73-5.76. This includes the following:

"The design concept for the development is based on individual "villages" each with its own identity, whilst integrating with each other and the existing urban area. The green infrastructure corridors between these settlements is the principal defining site feature and the village concept works well within these existing constraints"

"The development form at the New Eastern Villages will be structured around green spaces, particularly associated with the River Cole corridor and its tributaries. Development will protect and enhance existing green infrastructure, defined in policy EN1, and provide new green infrastructure in accordance with that policy.

The impact on views to and from the North Wessex Downs, will be mitigated through measures identified in the landscape assessment, including off site mitigation if necessary, and considered in the context of Swindon's existing position in relation to the North Downs such that there is no net detriment to the AONB, accepting that development will be visible.

Proposals for development must integrate and connect with wider Swindon green infrastructure network"

Overarching design principles include:

- To create new, distinct villages with individual identities linked together by green spaces, which integrate with the existing urban area;
- To respect the landscape context, natural and historic environmental features and identity of the surrounding villages.

New Eastern Villages: South Marston

8.3.11 The Site falls within the allocation that forms part of the proposed expansion of South Marston (Policy RA3). This forms one of the New Eastern Villages as part of Policy NC3.

8.3.12 In summary, and in relation to landscape matters, Policy RA3 states:

"b. Development at South Marston shall:

Ensure it protects the character of the existing village:

- Provide green infrastructure in accordance with Policy EN1 proportionate to the scale of expansion;
- Provide an extended recreation ground to include the field to the south west of the current recreation ground with recreational facilities of an appropriate type and scale;
- Protect historical landscape features, archaeological assets and existing green infrastructure;

c. To ensure non-coalescence of South Marston with Swindon and the other proposed Eastern Villages, the land between the expanded village and the railway to the south shall remain part of the countryside…"

Natural and Built Environment

8.3.13 Turning to general landscape matters, Theme 7 of the Local Plan sets out polices to: "protect, enhance and manage the natural and built environment;

ensure that the appropriate provisions are in place to deliver green open space as part of new development".

8.3.14 Policy EN1 is concerned with Green Infrastructure (GI). The Policy states:

"a. Development shall protect and enhance green infrastructure and assets as identified in Appendix 5. This includes the requirement that development must provide for the protection and integration of visually or ecologically important existing trees, hedges and woodlands.

b. Development shall design green infrastructure and integrate with existing green corridors as identified on the Proposals Map, to maximise its connections and functions and ensure the sustainable maintenance and management of it."

8.3.15 Paragraphs 4.324 and 4.325 go on to say:

"...Swindon's green infrastructure will continue to play a key role in Swindon's sustainable growth and regeneration and it will sit at the heart of a far-reaching network of interconnected green spaces that:

- Connect and enrich biodiversity habitats and ecological networks;
- Improve access, recreation and tourism opportunities;
- Contribute to the health and well being of the residents of Swindon;
- Enhance landscape character and respect local distinctiveness;
- Help meet the challenges of climate change;
- Realise the potential of historical and cultural heritage features to contribute to local identity and sense of place; and
- Contribute to the health and wellbeing of the residents of Swindon.

The Swindon Green Infrastructure (GI) Strategy provides a comprehensive plan for the protection of existing and the creation of new green infrastructure in the borough."

8.3.16 Policy EN2 refers to the Great Western Community Forest (GWCF). One of England's 12 community forests, it was initiated in the 1990s and its principal aim is to deliver urban, economic and social regeneration.

8.3.17 The GWCF is about creating high-quality environments by diversifying land use, revitalising derelict landscapes, enhancing biodiversity and providing new

opportunities for recreation, cultural activity, education, and healthy living. A priority is to "achieve a substantial increase in tree and woodland cover across Swindon".

8.3.18 Policy EN2 states that:

"Development shall contribute towards the aims and objectives of the Great Western Community Forest (GWCF) in Swindon. This will be achieved by:

- Ensuring a net increase in tree cover through the planting of new woodland and trees;
- Creating or enhancing habitats for biodiversity, including built structures in accordance with Policies EN1 and EN4; and
- Ensuring access to local woodlands and opportunities for communities and businesses to benefit from the GWCF"

8.3.19 Policy EN5 is the principal landscape policy:

"a. Proposals for development should ensure that:

- The intrinsic character, diversity and local distinctiveness of landscape within Swindon Borough are protected, conserved and enhanced;
- The design of the development and materials used are sympathetic to the surrounding landscape;
- Unacceptable impacts upon the landscape are avoided; and
- Where other negative impacts are considered unavoidable, they are satisfactorily mitigated.

b. In meeting the requirements of EN5a, applicants for development should demonstrate how they have taken into account Landscape Character Assessments and assessed the potential impact of the proposal upon the following attributes of the landscape:

- Existing landscape form, features, topography and character;
- The contribution of the landscape to biodiversity and wildlife;
- Local geology and geo-diversity;
- Views, visual amenity and the landscape setting;
- Valuable historic and heritage areas and assets;
- Environmental amenity such as tranquillity & noise, pollution and light pollution; and
- The existing social, physical, economic and environmental roles and functions of the landscape at the local and strategic scale.

c. The North Wessex Downs Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty (AONB) is a nationally recognised area of landscape protection. Proposals within the Borough which are within and/or abuts the North Wessex Downs AONB must accord with relevant criteria set out in the AONB Management Plan. Proposals outside the AONB should not adversely affect its setting."

Draft Eastern Village Supplementary Planning Document (July 2013) and South Marston Draft Supplementary Planning Document (June 2013)

8.3.20 Supplementary Planning Documents are in the course of preparation for the eastern Villages and for South Marston and have recently been the subject of consultation. They provide further more detailed guidance.

8.3.21 The *Eastern Villages Draft Supplementary Planning Document (2013)* sets out the Eastern Villages Vision, which is to create well-designed places where people want to live, work and spend time. Amongst the key principles, the development will:

- sensitively and positively respond to the existing landscape context, natural and historic assets and the character and identity of the surrounding villages as well as enhancing biodiversity and green infrastructure;

- comprise new distinct villages with individual identities and characters linked together by green spaces that integrate with the existing urban area and wider landscape setting. .

8.3.22 The *South Marston Draft Supplementary Planning Document (2013)* provides a detailed planning framework setting out the expectations for development at South Marston, The SPD sets out a number of key development principles which include :

- Separation from other residential areas: maintain and visually enhance the separation of the village from the Swindon urban area, and any future development, by providing a gap of open amenity space;

- Rural Feel: maintain an open and rural feel by providing public open space accessible to the existing and future residents with green corridors that

safeguard views from the village to the North Wessex Downs Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty, the church and surrounding countryside;

8.4 BASELINE CONDITIONS

Baseline Landscape Context –Published Documents

National Context

Natural England: National Character Areas

8.4.1 Landscape character is assessed at a national level by Natural England through the use of National Character Areas (NCA). The assessment provides a very broad contextual understanding of an extensive landscape area and establishes the general characteristics of the wider landscape.

8.4.2 The vast majority of the Site lies within the Mid Vale Ridge Character Area see Figure 8.1 (**Appendix 8.1**). This is a relatively narrow, but long character area that forms a low east-west ridge gently rising above the lower lying Upper Thames Clay Vale Character Area. It stretches from the western edge of Swindon to the edge of Aylesbury in the east and encompasses the landscape of Oxford.

Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty (AONB)

8.4.3 The wider landscape around Swindon includes the Cotswolds AONB some way to the north, and the North Wessex Downs AONB to the south, which lies around 4km to the south of the Site and forms a ridge of higher land above Swindon and the Upper Thames Clay Vale. The location of the AONB in relation to the site is shown in Figure 8.1 (**Appendix 8.1**).

North Wessex Downs AONB

8.4.4 The North Wessex Downs AONB is characterised as chalk downland, river valleys and ancient woodland. The North Wessex Downs were designated as an AONB in 1972, and following the introduction of the Countryside and Rights of Way Act 2000, it has the same status as a National Park.

North Wessex Downs AONB Integrated Landscape Character Assessment (2002)

8.4.5 This Landscape Character Assessment provides an extensive analysis of the AONB through a series of Landscape Types and Landscape Character Areas.

8.4.6 Landscape Type 5*: The Downs Plains and Scarp* and Landscape Type 6: *Vales* are the immediate Landscape Types to the south of Swindon and form the northern edge of the AONB boundary see Figure 8.2 (**Appendix 8.1**).

8.4.7 The Downs Plain Scarp is defined as the following:
"The landscape of the Downs Plain and Scarp extends along the entire northern edge of the North Wessex Downs. It is defined by geology with the plain formed by the eroded surface of the Lower Chalk, creating a low, level surface, extending as a ledge at the foot of the high downs, linked to a distinctive steep escarpment."

8.4.8 This Landscape Type is subdivided into six Character Areas, with Landscape Character Area 5F: *Liddington-Letcombe Open Scarp* within this Type being the closest to the Site.

8.4.9 It is described as the following:
"The scarp is the defining edge of the AONB and is a highly visible feature from Swindon and Wantage and the adjacent low lying clay Vales. The strong landform dominates skyline views and provides a dramatic backdrop from these areas signalling the presence of the North Wessex Downs...Overall, the scarp with its varied landform, sheltered coombes and mix of villages, parklands and open pastures has a very attractive rural character"

8.4.10 The overall management objective is :
"...to conserve and enhance the attractive and open character of the scarp".

8.4.11 The management requirements include the following:
"...The strong skyline, which is a dominant feature from the low lying Vales should be conserved...Consideration should be given to the impact of new development beyond the AONB boundary on both the character of the AONB and in views from the higher ground".

8.4.12 Landscape Type 6: *Vales*, Character Area 6C: *Wanborough Vale* is defined as the following:

"At Wanborough, the AONB boundary includes a very small part of the wider lower lying Vale landscape that continues to the north of the AONB and east of Swindon as the Vale of White Horse. In this area the AONB boundary extends to the edge of the Swindon urban area at Coate. The character area therefore forms a very important area of open land between the base of the scarp (5E & 5F) at Liddington and the urban edge…The area possesses many of the characteristics of the wider Vale with tree and shrub-lined streams and ditches draining to the River Cole through a mixed pasture and arable landscape. Fields are medium scale and bounded by a network of hedgerows, with abundant hedgerow trees. This area, however, has a distinct 'urban fringe' character, with the surrounding road network being a dominant influence. The main M4 Swindon junction forms the southwest corner, and the straight A346, following the route of a Roman road cuts the western edge. The area is wholly visible from the surrounding road network. Other urban influences include recent development on the edge of Wanborough (main part of the settlement outside the AONB boundary) plus views to the edge of Swindon."

8.4.13 The overall management objective is:
"…to maintain this as an open agricultural landscape to provide a buffer between the urban expansion of Swindon and the scarp slope of the downs"

North Wessex Downs AONB Management Plan 2009-2014

8.4.14 The North Wessex Downs AONB Management Plan has been prepared by the North Wessex Downs Council of Partners. The Management Plan provides agreed objectives, policies and actions over the management period.

8.4.15 A relevant issue is:
"Expansion of the main urban areas just outside the AONB, including the main centres of Swindon, Reading, Newbury, Basingstoke and Andover, creating urban fringe pressures on the boundaries of the AONB"

8.4.16 Development Objective 13 refers to the following:

"To ensure that the formulation and implementation of planning polices across the North Wessex Downs takes full account of the purposes of designation and the character and the quality of the AONB and its setting"

8.4.17 Actions include:
"Promote the use of Landscape & Visual Impact Assessments for developments, including for those outside of but visible from the AONB, in order to maintain the area's distinctive character and setting."

North Wessex Downs AONB Position Statement, Setting 2012

8.4.18 The AONB unit and Council of Partners have prepared a position statement to inform local planning authorities, landowners and applicants regarding development outside, but within the setting of the AONB. The statement forms an extension to the principles explained within the North Wessex Downs Management Plan:

"The purpose behind this Position Statement is to inform local planning authorities, landowners, applicants and other interested parties regarding development outside but within the setting of the North Wessex Downs AONB. The document is intended to guide policy makers, to assist in the preparation of planning applications and to assist in the decision making process"

8.4.19 In terms of "avoiding harm" the AONB unit supports the following approach:
"Measures to consider impact on the setting of the AONB, including where required through Landscape and Visual Impact Assessments"

Local Context

Swindon Borough Council: Landscape Character Areas SPG 2004

8.4.20 Landscape character has been assessed within the Borough. The majority of the Site is located within the *Midvale Ridge*, which broadly covers the landscape to the east of Swindon, Figure 8.2 (**Appendix 8.1**).The *Midvale Ridge* comprises the landscapes around the villages of South Marston, Stanton Fitzwarren, Blunsdon and Hannington.

8.4.21 Key characteristics include the following:

- Main east/west ridge of Corallian Limestone with isolated areas of Oxford and Kimmeridge Clays.
- Lower Greensand and Kimmeridge Clay in the Coate area.
- Rolling landform of valleys, ridge, hill and plateau tops (90-140m).
- Ridge is dissected by the south/north valleys of the Rivers Ray and Cole.
- Open views across the Vale of the White Horse towards the High Downs.
- Open views across the Thames Vale towards the Cotswolds.
- Rivers Ray and Cole run north/south through the area, with numerous tributaries during the main valleys.
- Important lakes at Stanton Fitzwarren, Sevenhampton and Coate Water.
- Numerous substantial woodlands and shelter belts linked by hedgerows with standard trees (Stanton Great Wood).
- Important settlements occupy the highest hilltops (Blunsdon/Highworth).
- Smaller villages lie within the valleys.
- The A419 and A361 cross the area.
- The B4019 runs east/west along the ridge.
- The M4 motorway runs along the southern boundary in the Coate area.
- Extensive recreational areas between Swindon and Highworth.
- Fields generally moderate in size.
- Smaller fields around South Marston, Kingsdown Lane and Blunsdon.
- Generally enclosed by hedgerows and woodland.
- Iron Age hill fort at Blunsdon.
- Eighteenth century landscape at Stanton Fitzwarren.
- Disused Highworth railway line.
- Several mill sites.
- Coate Water supplied to the Wilts and Berks canal.

8.4.22 Landscape guidelines and development considerations include the following:

"The Midvale Ridge is characterised by two distinct areas, one to the north-east and one to the south of Swindon. The southern Midvale ridge area comprises the area of land to the south of Swindon that encompasses Coate Water and the open land to the west of Coate Water and is bounded by the M4 motorway, the eastern edge of Coate Water and Swindon's settlement boundary. The other Midvale Ridge Area contains the hilltop settlements of Blunsdon, Hannington and Highworth, which run

along the Corallian Ridge. Included within the Corallian Ridge are the small valley settlements of Stanton Fitzwarren, Sevenhampton and South Marston. The Midvale Ridge area enjoys views over the surrounding lower clay vales, particularly northwards over the Thames Vale..."

8.4.23 Development considerations for the Midvale Ridge Landscape Character Area proposals should:

- Ensure that non-developed hilltops remain free from development to preserve the prominence and quality of hilltop settlements.
- Where opportunities arise, provide for additional tree planting that maintains the scale and dispersed pattern of existing woodlands.
- Where appropriate, within the southern Midvale Ridge area, have regard to its close proximity to the Downs Plains and High Downs areas.
- Provide planting to contain the development within a discrete area, reflecting the undulations of the landscape.
- Retain the perception of distinctiveness and separation from Swindon within the Rural Buffer areas identified in the Local Plan.

8.4.24 The south eastern part of the Site is located within the Vale of the White Character Area. Key characteristics are the following:

- Northern half of Kimmeridge Clay;
- Southern half of Gault Clay;
- Narrow band of Lower Greensand dividing the two clays;
- Broad, flat, low lying valley (90m);
- Extensive views towards the Downs and Midvale Ridge;
- Numerous small streams flow across the vale from south to north, joining the River Cole;
- Numerous ponds;
- Very few woodlands;
- Fields bounded by hedgerows with scattered standard trees;
- Few scattered farms in the less accessible areas;
- A419(T), A420 and the London to Bristol railway line form the boundaries;
- Large fields with a strong north to south linear pattern following Parish boundaries;
- A deserted mediaeval village adjacent to Wanborough;

- Roman settlement and roads at Lotmead;
- The disused Wilts & Berks Canal runs along the northern boundary; and
- Substantial tree cover pre 1970 (Dutch Elm disease).

8.4.25 Landscape guidelines and development considerations include the following:

"The Vale of the White Horse extends eastwards from Swindon towards Shrivenham and beyond. Settlement patterns are generally limited to small scale agglomerations giving the perception of a remote landscape, which is distant from human activity. Views across this whole area are far reaching, due to its fairly level terrain with only minor undulations. The south-western corner of the Vale of the White Horse Character Area, comprising the land to the south of Pack Hill, lies within the North Wessex Downs Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty, a nationally important landscape designation for which Local Plan Policy ENV11 provides a number of development constraints."

8.4.26 Within the Vale of White Horse Landscape Character Area proposals should:

- Ensure that the scale and massing of development does not adversely affect the area's perception of remoteness;
- Where appropriate, have regard to the area's close proximity to, and in the case of the land to the south of Pack Hill, its location within, the North Wessex Downs Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty;
- Where opportunities arise, provide additional tree planting to increase tree cover by creating blocks of woodland;
- Reflect the existing pattern of isolated units through an open, dispersed development pattern;
- Where opportunities arise, provide planting that reinforces existing hedgerows to compensate for the trees lost to Dutch Elm disease during the 1970s; and
- Retain the perception of distinctiveness and separation from Swindon within the Rural Buffer area identified in the Local Plan.

A Green Infrastructure Strategy for Swindon 2010-2026 (2011)

8.4.27 The Borough Council have prepared a Green Infrastructure (GI) Strategy. Its aims are as follows:

- Prioritise the planning, development of and investment in green infrastructure in Swindon to 2026;
- Present a shared vision for the development of a strategic green infrastructure network across the Borough of Swindon and reaching into neighbouring areas;
- Highlight the means in which the organisations, communities and partnerships can work to create and sustain a fit for purpose green infrastructure network across the area; and
- Consolidate the essential role green infrastructure will play in the sustainable development of Swindon.

8.4.28 The GI strategy will be used to:

- Provide the basis for the coordinated approach to the creation and sustained management of green infrastructure across Swindon and its neighbouring authorities;
- Support and guide the production of local development plan documents, particularly a Green Infrastructure Supplementary Planning Document for Swindon and master plans associated with major development areas;
- Provide a framework for the development of other localised green infrastructure plans;
- Act as a reference document to other key strategies such as community plans, sustainability strategies, local transport plans, and climate change action plans; and
- Act as a basis for a rolling 3 year GI delivery plan.

8.4.29 Section 4: *Proposals for enhanced Green Infrastructure across Swindon* includes a vision and a series of aims and objectives. This includes proposed GI networks across Swindon that are based upon strategic corridors, sub-regional corridors and local clusters. The former Eastern Development Area (now New Eastern Villages) is identified as a “local GI cluster”.

8.4.30 The OPA includes a supporting document: *Green Infrastructure Strategy-Guiding Principles*, based upon the objectives that are contained within *A Green Infrastructure Strategy for Swindon 2010-2026*, in addition to nationally recognised Green Infrastructure guidance form Natural England.

Oxfordshire Wildlife and Landscape Study (OWLS) 2004

8.4.31 It is relevant to consider landscape characterisation that has been undertaken in the neighbouring local authority, as the Site's south eastern corner, near Acorn Bridge, borders Oxfordshire and the Vale of White Horse District. At a County level the Oxfordshire Wildlife and Landscape Study (OWLS) provides landscape characterisation. The Clay Vale Landscape Character Type and the Rolling Farmland Landscape Character Area are the closest Landscape Type and Character Areas to the site (see **Appendix 8.1**).

8.4.32 The Landscape Strategy for the Clay Vale is to:

"Conserve the intimate, tranquil and small-scale pastoral character of the landscape. Conserve and enhance the well-defined pattern of hedgerows, hedgerow trees and tree-lined watercourses."

8.4.33 For the Rolling Farmland Character Landscape Type, the Landscape Strategy is to;

"Conserve and enhance the surviving pattern of woodlands, hedgerows, hedgerow trees and tree-lined watercourses. Minimise the impact of built development through appropriate location, choice of building materials, and the use of locally characteristic tree and shrub species."

8.4.34 At a District level, Vale of White Horse District Council includes a Landscape Strategy within its Planning Advisory Note (2006). The closest character area to the site is Zone 2: Clay Vale - 2a Western Clay Vale. This is an extensive Character Area extending form the western county boundary to the edge of Wantage to the east.

Baseline Site Landscape Context

8.4.35 The following provides an overview of the Site in term of its land uses, main landscape features and surrounding context. An annotated Aerial Photograph, figure 8.3 (**Appendix 8.1**) illustrates the Site and its relationship with the surrounding landscape and urban context.

Context

8.4.36 In broad terms, the Site forms a parcel of agricultural land lying between the village of South Marston to the north and the A420 and the Great Western railway line to the south.

8.4.37 Although predominantly an agricultural landscape, the Site lies close to the urban edge of Swindon and there are a number of urbanising elements that lie near to the Site, or in close proximity, which have a strong urban influence on the landscape. This includes, amongst others, the A419 (Swindon by-pass), the A419-A420 White Hart interchange and large buildings at St Margaret's Retail Park to the west; the extensive South Marston Industrial Estate and Keypoint Distribution Centre to the north and west which includes a number of large employment buildings and distribution warehouses; and the railway and A420 which run parallel with one another to the south.

8.4.38 The Site boundary is defined by a combination of the curtilage of farms and properties, hedgelines, public rights of way, roads and by the edge of South Marston village.

8.4.39 South Marston village (together with Nightingale Lane) form the Site's northern boundary. The southern edge of the village is defined by residential properties, South Marston primary school and the Mercure South Marston Hotel and Leisure Club, as well as an industrial/employment area off Thornhill Road.

8.4.40 Residential properties that border, or lie close to the site are largely modern late 20th century in character and architecture and these include properties at Ash Gardens, Manor Park, Rawlings Close, Bell Gardens and Yew Tree Gardens. In general, the older part of South Marston is concentrated around the Church (St Mary Magdalene) at the northern end of Old Vicarage Lane, and around the junction with Chapel Lane and Thornhill Road-Highworth Road.

8.4.41 Nightingale Lane also defines the Site's northern boundary. This narrow lane extends in a north-easterly direction from South Marston towards Nightingale Wood, a publicly accessible woodland of broadleaved and coniferous trees that was planted in the 1990s. The site's eastern boundary is defined by the wood and by hedgerows.

8.4.42 The River Cole lies to the east of Nightingale Wood, set within a continuous belt of woodland that stretches from Sevenhampton to the north to the A420 to south. To the east of the River Cole are the larger settlements of Shrivenham and Watchfield, and the smaller villages of Lower Bourton and Bourton.

8.4.43 The Site's western boundary is defined by a series of hedgerows close to Thornhill Road. Further to the west and north of South Marston is the industrial and employment area of South Marston Industrial Estate, which is accessed from the A361. The area includes a number of large scale employment buildings and distribution warehouses and this includes the Honda complex, G-Park (DHL and B&Q Distribution Centre) and the buildings at Keypoint Distribution Centre and Keypoint Railfreight Interchange.

8.4.44 To the north of South Marston are the villages of Stanton Fitzwarren and Sevenhampton.

8.4.45 The Site's southern boundary is defined by the railway line which for most of its course alongside the Site is on embankment, or the A420. The A420 lies immediately south of the railway line following a similar alignment. Wiltshire County Police Headquarters, St Margaret's Retail Park and a Sainsbury's retail store lie to the west close to the A420 -A419 (White Hart) interchange.

8.4.46 The landscape to the south of the A420 is characterised by the lower lying agricultural landscape of the River Cole. Fields and hedges are interspersed with scattered farms and properties which include Lotmead Farm, Mount Pleasant Farm and Lower Earlscourt Farm.

8.4.47 The villages of Wanborough, Hinton Parva and Bishopstone lie on the edge of the North Wessex Downs scarp above the River Cole valley and the urban area of Swindon. There are extensive views from the escarpment across the valley and over to Swindon.

8.4.48 A number of farms and properties lie to the south of South Marston, surrounded by the Site. These include Priory Farm, Manor Farm, Acorn Bridge Farm, Longleaze Farm, Marston Farm, South Marston Farm, Home Farm, Rowborough Farm and Red

House. As well as residential properties on the southern edge of South Marston, there are also a number of properties that align Old Vicarage Lane as it heads southwards towards the A420. This includes the Carpenters Arms Public House.

Designations

8.4.49 The Site is not subject to any statutory landscape quality designations, nor is the local landscape. Within the wider Study Area is the North Wessex Downs AONB to the south, which lies around 4km from the Site at its closest point, and the Cotswolds AONB which lies to the north of Swindon, approximately 13km from the Site at its closest point.

8.4.50 Conservation Areas are located in Lower and Upper Wanborough and Hinton Parva on the North Wessex Downs escarpment, Stanton Fitzwarren and Sevenhampton to the north of the Site, and within Stratton St Margaret (in Swindon) to the west. In close proximity to the Site are the farmhouses of Priory Farm, Manor Farm and Nightingale Farm which are Grade II Listed, as is the residential property of The Red House. Chapter 10 (Historic Environment) provides further baseline information on heritage assets within the local area.

Land Use

8.4.51 The Site is currently in agricultural use and largely comprises arable fields with some improved pasture for cattle grazing. The field pattern is typical of the wider landscape with fields being generally irregular in shape and predominantly small in scale, although there are some bigger fields to the east near Rowborough Farm

8.4.52 Hedgerows and ditches define the field pattern. Many of the hedges are tall and thick containing a number of mature trees, although some are variable in quality, largely due to current management practices. As well as some wet ditches associated with hedgelines, there are some small field ponds within the Site. Broad leaved plantation woodland occurs in the form of recently planted, willow dominated, woodland. Some coniferous planting also occurs.

8.4.53 The narrow South Marston Brook (a tributary of the River Cole) runs through the eastern part of the Site. It is heavily shaded along much of its length by adjacent trees and scrub.

8.4.54 There are a number of Public rights of way (PROW) that cross the Site, mostly in a north-south direction between South Marston and the A420. A Public Bridleway heads into Nightingale Wood via Rowborough Farm.

Topography

8.4.55 The landform character of the Site and the wider Study Area is illustrated in Figure 8.4 **(Appendix 8.1)**. The main part of the Site is relatively flat in character. The site varies between 100-90m Above Ordnance Datum with the higher part of the site at Nightingale Wood to the east. The Site gently falls in a south easterly direction towards the South Marston Brook and the River Cole.

8.4.56 The landform begins to gently rise to the north of South Marston at Stanton Fitzwarren (124m AOD) and Reddown Hill (135m AOD) before reaching the higher land of the Cotswolds AONB to the north. To the south of the Site, there are some small occasional rises at Mount Pleasant Farm (103m AOD) and at Bourton (105m AOD), but in the main the landscape is characterised by the wide and generally flat Cole Valley (90-95m AOD). Steeply rising slopes occur on the edge of the North Wessex Downs with Upper Wanborough at 140m AOD. Charlbury Hill, near Hinton Parva, reaches 253m AOD.

Landscape Character and Context

8.4.57 To inform the Proposed Development and to understand the Site's capacity to absorb development, the baseline landscape character and visual resources of the Site and surrounding landscape have been assessed.

8.4.58 The aim is to ensure that the Proposed Development minimises adverse landscape and visual impact, through carefully designed landscape and urban design strategies as part of the masterplanning process. This approach seeks to protect and conserve features of landscape value as an integral part of the scheme and at the same time

deliver compensatory habitats and maximise opportunities for landscape benefits, through landscape enhancement in terms of extensive areas of accessible greenspace for formal and informal recreation, as well as habitat creation to strengthen existing retained habitats and to enhance biodiversity.

8.4.59 An appraisal of visual resources has been prepared in parallel with an appraisal of the landscape. This has identified what is considered to be the 'visual envelope' of the Site; i.e. the extent in which the site, and therefore the Proposed Development may be visible, together with viewpoints that are judged to provide vantage points for receptors (residents, users of rights of way, highway users) that would view the Proposed Development.

Landscape Condition & Sensitivity

8.4.60 A landscape appraisal has been undertaken to assess the character, value and sensitivity of the Site and the surrounding landscape. This has been formulated through fieldwork and by analysing published landscape characterisation that has already been completed at a national and local level. Figure 8.2, **Appendix 8.1** illustrates representative Landscape Character Areas and these are taken from the Swindon Borough Landscape Character Areas SPG, the North Wessex Downs AONB Integrated Landscape Character Assessment and the Vale of White Horse Landscape Strategy.

8.4.61 A Landscape Baseline & Effects Table (LBET) (see **Appendix 8.3**) includes a baseline analysis of each Landscape Character Area with a judgement on the sensitivity of the landscape in term of its susceptibility to change (e.g. high, medium or low) and its value (e.g. high, medium and low).

8.4.62 From the baseline analysis, a number of reasoned conclusions can be drawn:

Baseline Landscape Summary

1) The vast majority of the Site lies within the *Midvale Ridge* Landscape Character Area as defined by the Swindon Borough Landscape Character Areas SPG.

2) The Site and the wider local landscape is not situated within a landscape that is afforded any statutory landscape quality protection/designation at an international, national, regional or local scale.

3) The Site is some distance away from the landscapes of the North Wessex Downs AONB (c4km) and the Cotswolds AONB (c13km). The Site does not play an intrinsic role within these landscapes.

4) The Site lies within the lower lying landscape of the River Cole valley and is largely flat in its character.

5) It is an intensively farmed landscape, which comprises arable land and some grazing fields, together broadleaved woodland (planted as a sustainable biofuel crop).

6) The Site's fields are sub-divided by hedgerows, footpaths, lanes and a road (Old Vicarage Lane). It includes a number of field ponds, wet ditches and the narrow South Marston Brook.

7) Hedgerows vary in their condition, quality and biodiversity and this is dependent on agricultural practices. Eight of the Site hedgerows are identified as being "important" under the Hedgerow Regulations.

8) There are a number of mature trees across the Site mainly associated with hedgerows and the South Marston Brook. The dominant species within hedgerows is ash along with oak and some field maple. Pollarded crack willow (mature and over mature status) is located along the course of the Brook and around ponds, ditches and drains. There are five mature trees considered to be "Category A - high quality" in arboricultural terms and this includes a single Veteran Tree (refer to Arboricultural Assessment (**Appendix 9.9**).

9) The local landscape within 1-2km to the north and west is strongly influenced by urban elements that extend around the edges of Swindon. This includes the main transport routes of the A420, A419, the railway line and large scale employment and industrial buildings (e.g. South Marston Industrial Estate and Keypoint Railfreight Interchange).

10) The Site's landscape character is influenced to varying degrees by its intervisibility with urban components such as passing trains on the elevated railway line and the urban edge of South Marston, which includes industrial buildings off Thornhill Road. There is, in certain locations within the Site,

intervisibility with the taller industrial/distribution buildings at South Marston Industrial Estate, Honda, G-Park, Keypoint Distribution Centre and Keypoint Railfreight Interchange.

11) Features of local landscape value within the Site are the South Marston Brook and its associated corridor, and the network of hedgerows and mature tree cover. These features are worthy of conservation and enhancement where important and unless outweighed in the master planning process

12) The Site and the wider local landscape is not considered to be particularly distinctive in landscape character, nor is it considered to be a highly valued landscape in overall landscape terms. It is not judged to be a special landscape of particular scenic beauty, certainly not in contrast to the North Wessex Downs AONB, for example.

13) The main bulk of the Site comprises arable land and in essence is an intensively farmed agricultural landscape similar to much of the wider Cole valley landscape around the fringes of Swindon. It also has a strong inter-relationship with South Marston village and visibility with the nearby urban edge of Swindon, including main transport routes.

14) Overall, the Site is judged to be of **medium landscape sensitivity/medium susceptibility to change**

Baseline Visual Resource

8.4.63 The interaction of buildings, vegetation and topography determines the potential for views of the Site. An analysis of the Site's visual envelope and the availability of views of the Site has been undertaken in parallel with the baseline landscape appraisal.

Receptors and viewpoints

8.4.64 Receptors that may have views of the Site include: residents; users of rights of way; users of open spaces and recreational facilities; highways users; and people at their place of work. In general, the first two categories (residents and users of rights of way) are normally of higher sensitivity than the latter two, although the surrounding context can, in some cases, have a bearing on sensitivity.

8.4.65 A series of representative viewpoints have been selected and photographs have been taken from these points see figures 8.5-8.6 (**Appendix 8.2**). The photographs illustrate various degrees of Site visibility and they assist in determining the Zone of Theoretical Visibility (ZTV), i.e. the area in which the Proposed Development may be visible.

8.4.66 The viewpoints that have been selected are considered to offer the main public views/vantage points that are potentially available. Direct views from private properties has not been possible. However, where practicable, photographs have been taken from nearby public vantage points to provide a representative view. Photographs were taken on the 4th March 2013 and provide late winter views, which provide 'worst case views' the absence offseasonal foliage which provides filtering and screening..

8.4.67 A Visual Baseline & Effects Table (VBET) is included at **Appendix 8.4**. This includes a baseline analysis of each viewpoint with a judgement on the sensitivity of the receptor in term of its susceptibility to change (e.g. high, medium or low) and its value (e.g. high, medium and low).

Baseline Visual Summary

8.4.68 From the analysis of the baseline visual resource, a number of reasoned conclusions can be drawn:

1) The Site is well contained within the wider landscape by a combination of the following:
    a. The built form of Swindon to the west and South Marston to the north;
    b. Woodland cover at Nightingale Wood to the east and further areas of woodland to the east and north;
    c. The railway embankment to the south; and
    d. Overlapping hedgerows and mature trees within the Site and the relatively flat nature of the Site itself;
2) The availability of clear and open views of the Site from the wider landscape is relatively limited.

3) There are no clear views of the Site from the settlements of Bourton, Sevenhampton, Shrivenham or Stanton Fitzwarren.

4) Views into the Site from the eastern suburbs of Swindon, such as Stratton St. Margaret, are screened and restricted by large industrial/distribution buildings along the A419 corridor, including the Keypoint Railfreight Interchange.

5) From elevated vantage points along the edge of the North Wessex Downs escarpment, such as Hinton Parva for example, the Site is distant (around 4km away), difficult to distinguish and barely, if at all, perceptible to the casual observer. This is largely due to distance as well intervening hedges and tree cover within the valley landscape.

6) Receptors on the edge of the North Wessex Downs scarp experience open and long ranging panoramic views across the vale. This includes views of the urban area of Swindon as well as the large employment buildings around the eastern fringes of the town, which although distant, are noticeable because of their scale.

7) From public viewpoints within the Site, there are distant views to the higher land of the North Wessex Downs to the south.

8) The availability of open and clear views into the Site is largely confined to close range views from localised viewpoints. This includes residents on the edge of South Marston, Old Vicarage Lane and users of rights of way. The relatively flat landform character of the Site and the network of overlapping hedgerows and mature trees tends to restrict the extent of visibility across the Site for these local receptors.

9) Depending on location, there is some intervisibility between the Site and the A419.

10) The railway embankment provides a strong visual screen which limits visibility to/from the south. Passing trains on the embankment are a noticeable urbanising feature within this landscape and there are transient and fleeting views of the Site for rail users.

11) There is intervisibility between some parts of the Site and the nearby residential edge of South Marston.

12) There is also intervisibility between the Site and local properties and farms that lie in close proximity such as Rowborough Farm, South Marston Farm and

Manor Farm. The intervening network of hedgelines and trees provides some filtering of views across the Site from these receptors.

13) From the slightly higher parts of the Site, near Nightingale Wood, there are views of buildings in South Marston, as well as of the large employment and distribution buildings at Keypoint and South Marston Industrial Estate on the skyline.

8.5 POTENTIAL EFFECTS

Construction and Post-completion stages

8.5.1 The potential landscape and visual effects (both adverse and beneficial) arising from the Proposed Development have been identified as part of the iterative design process.

8.5.2 Without a considered and responsive approach to masterplanning, which includes the retention of landscape features such as the South Marston Brook, important hedgerows and mature trees where possible, and their enhancement as part of the GI framework, the potential adverse effects at both construction and post-completion stages could include the following:

1) Significant/major landscape harm through the complete loss and removal of *all* landscape features of value within the Site, as well *no* compensatory landscape habitats or any additional landscape enhancement.
2) Significant/major adverse effect on the landscape and visual resource, through a poorly conceived masterplan in terms of the scale of development and the disposition of land uses, which does not take into account the findings of the baseline landscape and visual evaluation and identified features within the site that are worthy of retention.
3) Significant/major adverse effect on the visual resource and landscape character through the removal of all existing site features which provide screening effects, such as hedgerow and tree planting, and *no* replacement or additional planting to provide containment or screening effects.

8.6 MITIGATION MEASURES

Construction Stage

8.6.1 Site hoardings would shield views from the presence of construction equipment on the Site including vehicles, cranes, compounds, partially constructed buildings/structures and disturbed areas of ground.

Post-Completion Stage

8.6.2 The Proposed Development incorporates integral mitigation by virtue of its design, which has evolved iteratively to minimise adverse effects.

8.6.3 The proposed Green Infrastructure framework (GIF) provision as shown on the Development Framework Plan **(Appendix 2.1)** has been developed to avoid, reduce and offset any significant adverse effects arising from the Proposed Development At the same time, the GIF seeks to provide compensatory landscape features, as well as delivering long term landscape and recreational benefits, in addition to ecological enhancement.

Green Infrastructure Framework (GIF)

8.6.4 Further information on the site's GIF provision is explained within the *Green Infrastructure Framework (GIF) - Guiding Principle*s document that accompanies the OPA (**Appendix 8.5)**. The following provides a summary of the GIF for the Proposed Development.

8.6.5 The provision and approach to GIF is in accordance with *A Green Infrastructure Strategy for Swindon 2010-2026* and the initiatives of the Great Western Community Forest. It also accords with established guidance from Natural England and Sport England in terms of accessibility to greenspace for new communities and delivering multifunctional landscapes that offer recreation and biodiversity gains.

8.6.6 The Development Framework Plan and the location of development parcels has been guided by the natural assets with the Site such as South Marston Brook, the network of hedgerows and mature trees, and rights of way. In addition to this, the

Development Framework Plan has been carefully devised to take into account the context and setting of nearby residential properties within South Marston, in addition to surrounding farmsteads such as South Marston Farm and Manor Farm.

8.6.7 The Development Framework Plan responds to the site's landscape character by conserving features of landscape value within the Site (brook, important hedgerows and mature trees). These are conserved within corridors of new greenspace and strengthened by new habitat creation.

8.6.8 The Proposed Development seeks to minimise the inevitable landscape impact that would result as a consequence of new urban development on a greenfield site. At the same time, the Proposed Development has sought to mitigate against disruption in landscape character by providing for new hedgerow and tree planting to compensate for the removal of vegetation, and at the same time maximise opportunities for landscape enhancement by providing a substantial GIF to deliver long term landscape, ecological and recreational benefits.

8.6.9 The GIF framework equates to some 70ha or over 40% of the site. It includes the following components:

1) The creation of a large multifunctional landscape habitat within the Proposed Development. Although this will be perceived as a single extensive and connected area of greenspace offering a variety of habitats, it is, separated into three areas to aid explanation (see the accompanying Green Infrastructure Framework (GIF) - Guiding Principles, for locations):

   - **Zone 1: South Marston Park.** This is located to the west of Old Vicarage Lane. It encompasses retained trees, hedges and rights of way, together with new habitat creation in the form of new broadleaved planting of woodland copses, hedges and trees, and grassland meadows and SUDS (basins and swales). The park will include new sports pitches (alongside the existing recreation ground) and areas of equipped play.

- **Zone 2: Rowborough Park.** This lies to the east of Old Vicarage Lane and is broadly defined by South Marston Brook. It encompasses the Brook and its associated tree cover and floodplain, as well as retained trees, hedgerows and rights of way. It also includes new sports pitches, equipped play areas and habitat creation in the form of new broadleaved planting, SUDS and grassland meadows.

- **Zone 3: Nightingale Park.** This lies in the south eastern part of the Site and comprises new sports pitches, allotments and habitat creation which include SUDS.

2) "Greenways" and "Pocket Parks". These are defined corridors or areas of natural greenspace that essentially connect with the three parks. They contain existing hedgerows and trees and deliver opportunities for habitat creation in the form of new planting, as well providing for informal recreation to include walking, cycling and natural play.

3) Retained mature trees within the development parcels, which provide an opportunity in which to deliver feature spaces within the detailed layout.

4) New street trees and pockets of incidental greenspace and planting within development parcels, in addition to private gardens.

8.6.10 The design approach near South Marston has been carefully developed to minimise the impact of the Proposed Development on the existing community. The approach adopted includes the use of new sports pitches and greenspace as part of Zone 1: South Marston Park. This will provides a sensitive interface between the new built form and the existing edge of village and at the same time establish an active area of accessible greenspace for both communities.

8.6.11 There are 10 guiding objectives for the development's GIF:

1) To embrace the principles and aspirations that are set out within *A Green Infrastructure Strategy for Swindon 2010-2026*, the Great Western Community Forest and Natural England's Green Infrastructure Guidance.

2) To ensure that the GIF is multifunctional in its design so that it delivers long term landscape, biodiversity, recreation and sustainability benefits.

3) To minimise impacts on landscape character and biodiversity by retaining existing landscape features of value, such as hedgerows and mature trees, and to strengthen these habitats with new broadleaved planting to provide net gains overall.

4) To deliver a varied GIF which includes existing habitats, as well as the creation of swales, basins, ponds and wetland areas; species rich hedgerows; broadleaved woodland; native trees and shrub planting; and grassland meadows.

5) To develop a mix of species (to be finalised at the detailed stage) which will be based upon an appropriate range of native species that can be found within the local and wider landscape of the Midvale Ridge Character Area.

6) To ensure that the GIF is interconnected so that it provides greenspace and wildlife corridors that permeate within and around the development, with connections to South Marston Brook and Nightingale Wood.

7) To create a GIF that is publicly accessible so that all residents can easily access an area of greenspace for walking and cycling, as well as play, sport and informal recreation.

8) To deliver new sports provision, equipped play, pocket parks and large areas of open space for active sport and play and healthy active living.

9) To retain and /or divert the Site's rights of way and create new multipurpose recreational routes within the GIF for walking and cycling, which provide access around the Proposed Development as well as delivering improved access to the wider landscape.

10) To minimise the impact of the Proposed Development on the existing community of South Marston and surrounding properties that lie in close proximity through a well-considered masterplan and GIF.

Summary

8.6.12 Over 40% of the Site is dedicated as GI with retained habitats (hedges, mature trees, brook, ponds and rights of way), extensive habitat creation (broadleaved woodland, hedgerows and wetland habitats) and accessible greenspace (sports pitches, equipped play provision, allotments informal recreation, and walking and cycling routes).

Built Form

8.6.13 Design principles are contained within the Design and Access Statement that accompanies the OPA. In terms of the built layout and urban form, the Proposed Development will follow an accepted 'placemaking' approach of legible streets and spaces that are defined and enclosed by buildings.

8.6.14 Buildings will predominantly be two storeys in height to reflect the surrounding local character. The maximum building height from ground level to ridge level excluding any point features will be 12.5m.

8.6.15 It is anticipated that the built form and the use of materials, colours and finishes will respond and relate to the local context of South Marston and surrounding villages, to ensure the Proposed Development relates well to its setting.

8.7 RESIDUAL EFFECTS

Landscape Effects

8.7.1 The Landscape Baseline & Effects Table (LBET) (**see Appendix 8.3**) provides an assessment of effects during the construction phase, as well as effects on the landscape based on two scenarios: Year 1 and Year 15. Year 1 is upon completion of the Proposed Development and assumes a 1 year old GIF. This is effectively a 'worst case scenario'. Year 15 assumes a 15 year old GIF which is established and maturing.

8.7.2 The following paragraphs provide an explanation and summary of the landscape effects and should be read in conjunction with the LBET.

Overview

8.7.3 The site is relatively flat and the majority of the land comprises arable fields, with some grazing fields- all being sub-divided by hedgerows. The narrow well treed South Marston Brook is considered to be an important local landscape feature, whilst the network of hedgerows, mature trees, and rights of way are features of landscape value within the site. The hedges are variable in quality as a result of management practices. Although lying outside the site, Nightingale Wood is considered to be an important local landscape feature.

8.7.4 Depending on context, the site's existing landscape character is influenced and affected to varying degrees by nearby urbanising elements, such as passing trains on the railway line.

8.7.5 The northern part of the site lies alongside South Marston, which includes employment/industrial buildings at Thornhill Road and relatively modern residential properties on the fringes of the village. This part of the site, where it borders South Marston, is urban edge in landscape terms.

8.7.6 The local landscape near the site to the north and north west, near the fringes of Swindon, includes large scale employment buildings and distribution warehouses. In certain areas of the site these large scale buildings are noticeable element on the

skyline beyond the South Marston and these have, to varying degrees, an urban influence on its character.

8.7.7 The assessment of the site reveals a local landscape that is characterised by intensive agricultural use and one which is typical of much of the wider of the Midvale Landscape Character Area and indeed the agricultural landscape around the eastern fringes of Swindon. In overall landscape terms, the site is considered to be a pleasant agricultural landscape, but one which is not especially distinctive. In terms of the site's landscape sensitivity it judged to be of **medium susceptibility** to change and its value its considered to be **medium-low**.

8.7.8 For the Site, or indeed any greenfield site to absorb new development of the type, scale and nature that is proposed, there will be an inevitable disruption and initial adverse impact on the landscape. There will also be an obvious change in character with the agricultural fields, for example, being permanently lost and replaced by urban development. It is considered that there will be a **high adverse** magnitude of landscape change to the Site resulting from the Proposed Development.

8.7.9 The Proposed Development has been designed to minimise its impact on the landscape. Although there will be some disruption and losses in habitats to enable access into the Site, logical and practicable development parcels and a connected grid of streets, landscape features within the Site that are considered to be of value, such as the Brook, mature trees, ponds and rights of way are retained and these form key elements of the GIF

8.7.10 To compensate for some losses in hedgerows and vegetation, the GIF includes the provision of new native woodland, trees and hedgerow planting. This will provide mitigation for losses.

8.7.11 Moreover, the GIF will deliver a long term net gain in habitats and accessible greenspace across the Site in accordance with the initiatives of Great Western Community Forest. The GIF will assist is assimilating the Proposed Development within the local landscape as well as providing landscape and ecological benefits in the long term.

Landscape Effects - Construction

8.7.12 Inevitably there will be initial disruption to the Site's landscape during the construction stage and it is assessed that the magnitude of these landscape effects would vary depending on context. These will be limited to the local landscape of the Site and its immediate environs and as a result of the Site's containment within the wider landscape, it is judged that there would be no significant adverse landscape effects on the wider landscape during the construction stage.

8.7.13 The landscape impact during the construction stage is assessed as being transitory in its nature and, in conclusion, these effects are not judged to be significant in overall terms. All construction works would be carried out in full accordance with best practice procedures to minimise any adverse impact on landscape character. Existing features such as the South Marston Brook, mature trees and hedgerows that are retained, or adjacent to the Site boundaries, will be suitably and appropriately protected during the construction stage, following accepted best practice methods.

8.7.14 The overall significance of landscape effects during the construction stage is considered to be **moderate adverse.**

Landscape Effects – Post-completion

8.7.15 It is considered that the impact on the landscape as a result of the Proposed Development would be largely restricted to the Site and the local landscape. Impacts and resulting effects would be limited to a relatively small part of the Midvale Ridge Landscape Character Area.

8.7.16 It is judged that the Site's landscape would be able to accept change of the nature and type proposed, and this would not lead to a significant adverse effect on landscape character in the long term. These conclusions are reached by taking into account the following considerations:

1) The Site, and the local landscape around it, is not subject to any statutory landscape designations at an international, national, regional or local level.

2) The Site is remote from the highly valued landscapes of the North Wessex Downs AONB and Chiltern Hills AONB. The Site does not play a role in these landscapes and the Proposed Development would not lead to any significant adverse effects upon them.

3) The Site is not considered, either by this assessment or by any published local landscape characterisation, as being a landscape of 'high sensitivity'.

4) There are no significant *landscape* features within the Site, which would severely preclude or constrain its ability to accommodate development of the type and nature proposed.

5) The Site's landscape character is influenced by the adjacent urban/residential edge of South Marston and the urban edge of Swindon, which includes large scale employment, retail and distribution buildings within the local landscape and the transport routes of the A420 and the railway line.

6) The main part of the Site is taken up by intensively farmed arable land, similar to much of the surrounding context around the eastern edges of Swindon. It is a relatively flat landscape of fields, hedgerows and trees, which is influenced to varying degrees by nearby urban elements. It is not considered to be overly distinctive, or indeed special in landscape terms, but a rather unremarkable agricultural landscape.

7) The Proposed Development would retain existing landscape features within the Site and these elements would be strengthened by new habitat creation and greenspace.

8) The Proposed Development includes an extensive GIF which covers around 70ha (over.40%) of the Site. In the long term, at Year 15 and beyond, a maturing GIF which includes a variety of greensapces from sports pitches to wetland areas, would deliver landscape, ecological and recreational enhancement.

8.7.17 At Year 1, it is judged that that landscape effects of the Proposed Development would be **moderate adverse**. These effects would diminish between Years 1 to 15 as the GIF becomes established and delivers landscape and ecological benefits. On balance, it is considered that the adverse landscape effects on the Site at the outset would be reduced in the long term (Year 15 and beyond) by the very extensive,

multifunctional and varied GI that will be delivered as an integral part of the Proposed Development. By Year 15 the landscape effects are judged to be **minor adverse-negligible**.

Visual Effects

8.7.18 The Visual Baseline & Effects Table (VBET), is within **Appendix 8.4**

Summary

8.7.19 As part of the visual assessment, a representative Zone of Theoretical Visibility (ZTV) was established, based on the field work of the LVIA. The ZTV is a helpful tool by which to correlate the availability of views, the sensitivity of receptors and the potential visual effects of a development.

8.7.20 The ZTV does not define the precise extent of the visual impact of the Proposed Development, but illustrates the potential area in which there are expected to be full, partial or minimal views of the Proposed Development. Whilst the ZTV covers a relatively large area, there will be elements within it, such as tree groups, hedge lines and buildings that provide localised screening, which will limit the extent of visibility. Where the ZTV is distant from the Site, e.g. 2km+, the Proposed Development may be theoretically visible, but is likely to be difficult to distinguish. Further views may potentially occur outside the ZTV, although it is considered that the significance of these would be limited, given that the Proposed Development is likely to be very difficult to distinguish because of distance and intervening elements which are likely to curtail visibility.

8.7.21 The visual effects arising from the Proposed Development have been determined through:

- an analysis of the baseline viewpoints;
- the sensitivity of receptors from these viewpoints;
- the magnitude of visual change;
- the effect on the experience of receptors,
- the type, scale and nature of the Proposed Development; and
- the receiving context in which the Proposed development would be observed.

8.7.22 Professional judgement on the significance of effects has been an important part of this assessment in accordance with GLVIA3.

8.7.23 For this assessment, effects are based upon two scenarios: Year 1 and Year 15 as explained at 8.7.1. Visual effects on receptors are based on the parameters defined by the Development Framework Plan in terms of the layout of uses with the site and the scale and height of buildings.

Visual Effects – Construction

8.7.24 During the construction stage, some relatively short term reversible adverse effects upon the local visual resource will occur. This depends on the visibility of the Proposed Development from receptors and those in close proximity will normally have greater visibility. The majority of these views would be of large construction vehicles and associated machinery, together with views of site compounds and earthworks/ground modelling.

8.7.25 All construction works will be carried out in accordance with procedures to protect and to minimise as far as practicable adverse impacts on visual amenity. It is judged that a **moderate adverse** visual effect will occur during the construction stage, and effects will largely be localised to the Site and the immediate landscape.

8.7.26 The assessment has identified a range of receptors of varying sensitivities, enabling an assessment of the visual effects of the Proposed Development to be determined. The VBET includes the following:

- The sensitivity of the receptor in terms of its susceptibility to change and its value;
- The distance of the viewpoint to the closest part of the Site boundary;
- The proportion of the Proposed Development that would be visible in the view, i.e. full, partial, minimal or none.
- The scale of visual effect including degrees of contrast/integration with the landscape during the stages of the project i.e. construction, Year 1 and Year 15; and
- The overall significance of effects during the stages of the Proposed Development, i.e. construction, Year 1 and Year 15.

8.7.27 The following conclusions can be drawn:

- From the visual assessment, the Zone of Theoretical Visibility (ZTV) of the Proposed Development would be relatively limited in its extent on account of the Site being contained within the wider landscape by virtue of its relatively flat character and a network of overlapping hedges and trees in the surrounding landscape. Containment is also created by the surrounding built form of South Marston to the north and west, Nightingale Wood to the east, and the embankment of the railway line to the south. Opportunities in which to gain clear views of the Proposed Development from the wider landscape would therefore be limited;

- From the edge of the escarpment of the North Wessex Downs AONB, views of the Proposed Development would be difficult to distinguish due to distance and intervening screening features. Moreover, views of the Proposed Development (where these are perceived) would form a minor component of the overall view, which comprises a wide ranging panorama across the Cole valley. The Proposed Development would be seen within, and as part of, the urban area and visual envelope of Swindon. Consequently, it is considered that there would be no significant adverse visual effects on the North Wessex Downs AONB;

- Given their proximity to the Site, close range localised views would be afforded of the Proposed Development for residents of the southern edge of South Marston. These views would be predominantly from properties that border the Site at Manor Park and Ash Gardens, and to a lesser degree those that border the Site at Rawlings Close and Bell Gardens;

- The proposed Zone 1: South Marston Park of the GIF, together with overlapping retained mature hedgerows and trees, would assist in filtering the views of the built development, particularly from Rawlings Close and Bell Gardens;

- Again, given their proximity to the Proposed Development, a relatively small number of properties on Old Vicarage Lane and Nightingale Lane and adjacent farmsteads and properties at South Marston Farm, Manor Farm, Rowborough Farm and The Red House would have views of the Proposed Development. The actual extent of views of the built development from these localised receptors would vary with existing and new planting, as part of the GIF, filtering and restricting views of the built development;

- Users of the existing public rights of way that traverse the Site would experience close range views of the built development, as well as the proposed GIF;

- Highway users along Old Vicarage Lane, Thornhill Road and Nightingale Lane would experience close range transient views of the Proposed Development and the GIF as they travel through the landscape;

- There would be no clear views of the built development from the communities of Bourton, Stanton Fitzwarrren, Sevenhampton, Shrivenham, Wanborough, Hinton Parva and Stratton St. Margaret (Swindon).

8.7.28 To conclude, the visual effects of the Proposed Development would be limited to impacts upon localised receptors that are either within or close to the Site. The masterplanning approach and GIF has been devised to minimise adverse visual effects on these receptors through, for example, the setback of the built development and the provision of new woodland, hedgerow and tree planting.

8.7.29 It is judged that the Proposed Development would not result in any significant long term adverse visual effects. Visibility of the built development within the wider landscape would be restricted as a result of the existing containment and screening effects within the landscape, e.g. South Marston village, Nightingale Wood and the railway embankment. In addition, the GIF of new woodland and tree cover would, in the long term, strengthen this sense of containment.

8.7.30 Built development within the western part of the Site would be observed within the visual context and setting of the urban edge of South Marston village, and within a wider context of urban development to the north and west, principally the large scale

employment, retail and distribution buildings on the eastern edge of Swindon. The creation of a high quality development of homes, buildings and streets (and an extensive GIF that extends to around 40% of the Site) would be appropriate within this landscape context and would not be intrinsically harmful such that it would lead to any unacceptable visual harm.

8.7.31 Inevitably, there would be a high-medium adverse magnitude of visual change and it is considered that the Proposed Development as a result of its scale would result in a **moderate adverse** visual effect at Year 1. These effects would reduce between Years 1 and 15 and indeed beyond into the longer term, as the built development 'settles' into the landscape and receptors become accustomed to seeing the development within its context. More generally, by Year 15, the maturing GI framework of woodland, hedgerow and tree planting would provide screening and filtering effects for localised receptors and these would assist in assimilating the built development within the local landscape. This would continue, beyond Year 15, as woodland and tree cover has matured. It is considered that the overall significance of visual effects at Year 15 would be **minor adverse**.

Night Time Effects

8.7.32 It is anticipated that the Proposed Development will follow the latest best practice guidance on lighting installations to minimise lighting emissions and pollution on the surrounding landscape and on the night time skies. Overall, given the existing illumination of the local and wider area, the lighting effects on the night-time skies are not considered to result in a significant effect and the assessment concludes that effects would be **minor adverse**.

Residual Effects

8.7.33 The residual effects consider the magnitude and significance of any effects that would remain after the incorporation of mitigation measures. In the context of the landscape and visual impact assessment, the majority of these mitigation measures are intrinsic components of the design. In the longer term, the residual effects of the development's GI would continue to provide positive landscape and visual benefits.

Summary of Effects

8.7.34 The landscape effects identified are summarised in the Landscape Baseline and Effects Table **(Appendix 8.3)** and the visual effects identified are summarised in the Visual Baseline and Effects Table **(Appendix 8.4).**

8.7.35 It is considered that the site's landscape and the surrounding local landscape is not one which is overly distinctive, but a rather unremarkable agricultural landscape that is affected to varying degrees by the urban edge of Swindon and by urbanising influences. It is judged that the site has the ability in which to absorb urban development of the scale and type proposed without causing any unacceptable landscape and visual harm. Whilst there would be a moderate adverse landscape and visual effect at the outset (Year 1) these effects would reduce in the longer term (Year 15 and beyond) on an account of the GIF which would provide compensatory habitats and landscape enhancement. This includes an extensive, interconnected, accessible and multifunctional landscape that includes existing and new landscape features that covers some 70ha of the site. This would deliver new native woodland, tree and hedgerow cover; ponds, swales and wetland areas; sports pitches, play areas and allotments; and greenspace for natural and informal play, walking and cycling.

8.7.36 The overall landscape effects (Year 15) are judged to be **minor adverse-negligible** and the overall visual effects (Year 15) are considered to be **minor adverse.**